STIVEN CATALYST

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MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



KPIS

FEW GOALS, CLEAR ONES

Why a clear, difficult goal works better than “do your best”, what happens when there are too many, and when goals do harm.

49% of US employees strongly agree that they know what is expected of them at work. The item has fallen nine points since 2020.

GALLUP, 2026

INSIDE

COVER STORY

“Do your best” is not a goal

PAGE 03

THE RISK

When goals do harm

PAGE 06

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The goal card

PAGE 08

NO. 07 · KPIS

In this issue

A team with many goals in fact has few. Goals that work are specific, difficult and few; set badly, they do harm. Both sides are covered here.

In 2002 Edwin Locke and Gary Latham summed up three and a half decades of research on goals. George Doran gave managers SMART in 1981. In 2009 four researchers warned about the side effects of goals. And Gallup finds that only about half of US employees clearly know what is expected of them.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

03 COVER STORY
“Do your best” is not a goal

04 THE NUMBERS
Only half know what is expected

05 THE MODEL
SMART, and what it lacks

06 THE RISK
When goals do harm

07 HOW IT IS MEASURED
How many goals does your team have?

08 TOOL OF THE ISSUE
The goal card

09 SOURCES
Sources and method

HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

“Do your best” is not a goal

In 2002 Edwin Locke and Gary Latham summed up 35 years of research. The central finding: specific, difficult goals lead to better results than the call to “do your best”.

The reason: “do your best” has no reference point, so everyone measures it for themselves. Performance rose with the difficulty of the goal until it reached the limits of ability or commitment fell. Three things strengthen or weaken the effect: commitment to the goal, feedback on progress and the complexity of the task. On new, complex tasks a learning goal can work better than a number.

“Do your best”	Clear and difficult
No reference point	A number and a date
Everyone measures it alone	The same for everyone
Nobody knows when it is enough	Feedback shows where you stand

1981
Doran: SMART, five criteria for an objective.

2002
Locke and Latham: 35 years of research on goals.

2009
“Goals Gone Wild”: goals have side effects.

2012
4DX: one or two wildly important goals per team.

OUR READING

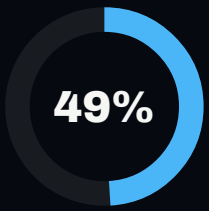
A vague goal leaves the pressure where it was and hands it to each person, who decides alone what “enough” means.

Sources: Edwin A. Locke & Gary P. Latham, American Psychologist, 2002; George T. Doran, Management Review, 1981; Lisa D. Ordóñez, Maurice E. Schweitzer, Adam D. Galinsky & Max H. Bazerman, 2009 (via The authors' manuscript (Penn repository)); Chris McChesney, Sean Covey & Jim Huling, 2012 (via FranklinCovey, Discipline 1, and summaries of the book)

THE NUMBERS

Only half know what is expected

Gallup asks employees whether they know what is expected of them at work. In the US this item has fallen more than any other since 2020.



of US employees strongly agree that they know what is expected of them (Gallup, 2026).

–9 points
since 2020, the largest drop among Gallup's twelve items in the US

0.42–0.80
effect size of specific, difficult goals over "do your best" in earlier reviews (Locke & Latham)

1–2
wildly important goals per team, as 4DX advises

Gallup places this item at the base of engagement: among its twelve elements, knowing what is expected is one of the two basic needs on which the others rest.

OUR READING

The question "do you know what is expected of you?" costs a minute. Not having the answer costs a shift.

Sources: Gallup, Indicator: Employee Engagement, 2026; Jim Harter, Gallup, 2026; Gallup, Gallup's Employee Engagement Survey: Ask the Right Questions With the Q12 Survey, 2026; Edwin A. Locke & Gary P. Latham, American Psychologist, 2002; Chris McChesney, Sean Covey & Jim Huling, 2012 (via FranklinCovey, Discipline 1, and summaries of the book)

THE MODEL

SMART, and what it lacks

George Doran wrote SMART in 1981, in a two-page article. In the original, A stood for “assignable” and R for “realistic”; later versions changed them.

01	02	03	04	05
Specific	**Measurable**	**Assignable**	**Realistic**	**Time-related**
One area, named clearly.	A number or a clear sign of progress.	Who owns it.	Achievable with the resources at hand.	When the result is due.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, ONE GOAL BEFORE AND AFTER

Before	Improve the service.
After	Cut delay complaints from 40 to 25 a week by 30 November; owned by the evening shift lead.

Invented numbers, for illustration.

SMART asks for

- A clear, measurable goal
- An owner, a deadline, a realistic target

The research adds

- Difficulty: hard goals do more
- Commitment, and feedback on progress

OUR READING

SMART makes a goal clear. It does not tell you whether it is the right goal, or how many goals a team can carry.

Sources: George T. Doran, Management Review, 1981; Edwin A. Locke & Gary P. Latham, American Psychologist, 2002

Doran himself wrote that not every objective has to be measured in numbers.

THE RISK

When goals do harm

In 2009 four researchers wrote that goals are like a prescription drug: they work, but they have side effects and need careful dosing.

01 **Narrow focus**
What is not measured is neglected, even when it matters.

02 **Unethical behaviour**
When the number is all that counts, some reach it by any means.

03 **Excess risk**
Specific, hard goals push people to riskier choices than vague goals do.

> HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A CALL CENTRE
> The team is measured only on call length. Agents close calls quickly, and customers call again. The number improves; the problem does not.

Locke and Latham contested the critique the same year. The authors of The 4 Disciplines of Execution (2012) add a practical limit: one or two wildly important goals per team, because the more goals at once, the fewer are achieved well.

OUR READING

The second question after “what is the goal?” is “what are we neglecting to reach it?”

Sources: Lisa D. Ordóñez, Maurice E. Schweitzer, Adam D. Galinsky & Max H. Bazerman, 2009 (via The authors' manuscript (Penn repository)); Edwin A. Locke & Gary P. Latham, Academy of Management Perspectives, 2009 (via Bibliographic record (Crossref)); Chris McChesney, Sean Covey & Jim Huling, 2012 (via FranklinCovey, Discipline 1, and summaries of the book)

HOW IT IS MEASURED

How many goals does your team have?

Goals arrive from many directions: the company, the boss, the customer, the audit. Counting them is the first step to making them few and clear.

1. **Count**
   Write down every goal, target or threshold the team is asked to hit, from every source.
2. **Ask the team**
   Have the team name the goals without notes. Mark the ones they mention.
3. **Choose**
   One or two for the quarter, with the reason why.
4. **Say it openly**
   What moves to second place, and who knows it.

> **HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A WAREHOUSE TEAM**
> The team has nine targets from three sources. Without notes, people name three. The lead picks two for the quarter and writes them on the board; the rest stay on the list but are not discussed every day. (Numbers invented.)

OUR READING

A team with nine goals has, in practice, one: the one the boss asked about last.

The steps and the example are the editors'.

More in the essay — Ten minutes before the shift: what the team needs to know before the work starts

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The goal card

One goal, one page. Fill it in with the team and put it where every shift sees it.

01 The goal, in one sentence from X to Y, by when

02 Why it matters for the customer or the team

03 What we do every week the signal that moves the goal

04 Who owns it one role, not a group

05 What we set aside so that this goal can happen

06 Review date, and where we are

The editors' proposal, built on Locke and Latham and on Doran. Keep confidential figures off the card.

Open the tool: KPI Diagnostic stivencatalyst.com/tools/kpi-diagnostic/

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

Building a Practically Useful Theory of Goal Setting and Task Motivation
Edwin A. Locke & Gary P. Latham, American Psychologist, 2002
https://doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.57.9.705

There's a S.M.A.R.T. way to write management's goals and objectives
George T. Doran, Management Review, 1981

Goals Gone Wild: The Systematic Side Effects of Overprescribing Goal Setting
Lisa D. Ordóñez, Maurice E. Schweitzer, Adam D. Galinsky & Max H. Bazerman, 2009 · via The authors' manuscript (Penn repository)
https://repository.upenn.edu/mgmt_papers/325

Has Goal Setting Gone Wild, or Have Its Attackers Abandoned Good Scholarship?
Edwin A. Locke & Gary P. Latham, Academy of Management Perspectives, 2009 · via Bibliographic record (Crossref)

The 4 Disciplines of Execution
Chris McChesney, Sean Covey & Jim Huling, 2012 · via FranklinCovey, Discipline 1, and summaries of the book
https://www.franklincovey.com/courses/the-4-disciplines/discipline-1-wildly-important/

Indicator: Employee Engagement
Gallup, 2026
https://www.gallup.com/394373/indicator-employee-engagement.aspx

Employee Engagement Declines From 2020 Peak
Jim Harter, Gallup, 2026
https://www.gallup.com/workplace/701486/employee-engagement-declines-2020-peak.aspx

Gallup's Employee Engagement Survey: Ask the Right Questions With the Q12 Survey
Gallup, 2026
https://q12.gallup.com/

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked “via”. The editors' interpretation is marked “Our reading”. Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

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Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

stivencatalyst.com/magazine/management-review.html

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